undermined the cohesion of even the most robust democracies. Populism has also mounted a radical challenge to the naive view of information. Populist leaders such as Donald Trump and Jair Bolsonaro, and populist movements and conspiracy theories such as QAnon and the anti-vaxxers, have argued that all traditional institutions that gain authority by claiming to gather information and discover truth are simply lying. Bureaucrats, judges, doctors, mainstream journalists and academic experts are elite cabals that have no interest in the truth and are deliberately spreading disinformation to gain power and privileges for themselves at the expense of 'the people'. The rise of politicians like Trump and movements like QAnon has a specific political context, unique to the conditions of the United States in the late 2010s. But populism as an anti-establishment worldview long predated Trump and is relevant to numerous other historical contexts now and in the future. In a nutshell, populism views information as a weapon.[20]



The populist view of information

In its more extreme versions, populism posits that there is no objective truth at all and that everyone has 'their own truth', which they wield to vanquish rivals. According to this world view, power is the only reality. All social interactions are power struggles, because humans are interested only in power. The claim to be interested in something else – like truth or justice – is nothing more than a ploy to gain power. Whenever and wherever populism succeeds in disseminating the view of information as a weapon, language itself is undermined. Nouns like 'facts' and adjectives like 'accurate' and 'truthful' become elusive. Such words are not taken as pointing to a common objective reality. Rather, any talk of 'facts' or 'truth' is bound to prompt at least some people to ask, 'Whose facts and whose truth are you referring to?'

It should be stressed that this power-focused and deeply sceptical view of information isn't a new phenomenon and it wasn't invented by anti-vaxxers, flat-earthers, Bolsonaristas or Trump supporters. Similar views were propagated long before 2016, including by some of humanity's brightest minds.[21] In the late twentieth century, for example, intellectuals from the radical left like Michel Foucault and Edward Said claimed that